

Evolving Olympics

The site at Olympia developed over many centuries, with buildings and statues added from the 6th century BCE onward. The core of the site was built around the sanctuary, the area between the temples of Zeus and Hera in this photo. Later additions included a wall between the stadium and sanctuary, training areas, and accommodation for visiting guests.



3 The Temple of Hera, Queen of the Gods, was the first temple built at Olympia, in the 6th century BCE.

4 The Temple of Zeus was the most important Olympic shrine. Built in the 5th century BCE, it housed a huge statue of Zeus.

5 The palaestra was where boxers and wrestlers trained. It was built in the 3rd century BCE.

Olympic coins

Special coins were produced for the festival by the city-state of Elis, which organized the games. The coins showed Zeus on one side and his sacred eagle on the other.



Written evidence

Much of what we know about the ancient Olympics comes from the detailed written accounts of early travelers. One of these was Pausanias, a Greek traveler and geographer who wrote a ten-volume book called *Description of Greece*.

